

ARCHITECTURE/ROBERT CAMPBELL

Only the names really differ

What on earth is a Royal Barry Wills?

That is the question that has been haunting me.

For that matter, what is a Gambrel Cape? A Split Trilevel? A Front-to-Back Ranch? Or an Embankment Ranch? Or a Straight Ranch? A Dutch, Split, Gambrel, Garrison or Center-Entrance Colonial?

I don't think I know a single architect who could give a very accurate definition of more than a couple of those terms, all of which are names of different types of developer-built single-family suburban houses culled from one page of the Sunday *Globe* real estate ads.

I found out about all these terms when a friend was looking for a house in Framingham. He became very expert in interpreting them and (being a scientist) proved that they all have very exact meanings, so that, if you go to see a house from the ad, you know in advance exactly what you will find.

The funny thing is, he couldn't have cared less whether he bought a Bracketed Gambrel or an Inverted Saltbox. All he wanted was a liveable plan and enough room, and the different models seemed to offer relatively little choice in these areas.

Builders certainly go to a lot of trouble to make you think there are great differences and people take pride in becoming knowledgeable about these things, just as they do with the equally infinitesimal differences between one Detroit car model and the next.

I have no moral for this

essay, except to note that it's just another example of the huge communications gap that still exists between architects and the public, each with its own jargon.

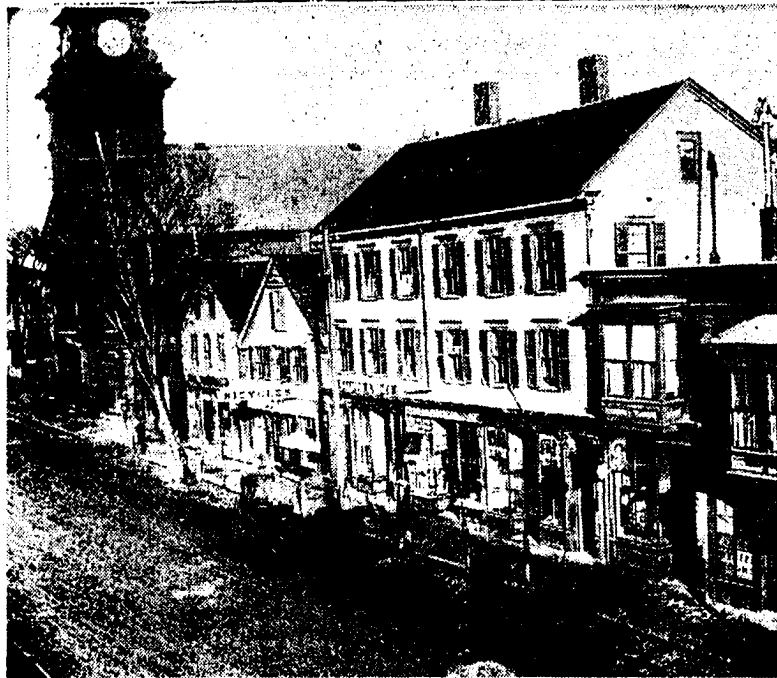
And to point out that people really do love to label and classify and discuss things. That's probably a reason why so many of us still have trouble coming to terms with more original-looking designs. My god, what is that? we say. It looks more like a Xerox machine than a house. Not like my Front-to-Back Ranch.

Ah, but who can resist a Royal Barry Wills? I hope I never see one, because it could never live up to what I imagine. Something soft, seen through a blue mist, tall white columns, the wisteria climbing...

An acquaintance, who is writing an article for *Columbia Journalism Review* about architecture critics, says there are only six regular ones in newspapers in this country — almost as rare a bird as the Spotted Gambrel.

How many art critics are there? A thousand? Or theater? Music? Film? Why do people only take an interest in their visual surroundings if someone puts a frame around them, or projects them on a screen?

Surely there was a time when Americans were more sensitive to their visual environment than they are now. Any old photograph of almost any American city up to 1910 or 1920 shows a harmony, a relatedness that we don't seem able to achieve so offhandedly today. The



two photos of Portsmouth, N.H., adjacent (courtesy of Vision, Inc.) make the point as well as any.

It was the automobile that cut in on the dance between man and his environment, between the viewer and the viewed. The automobile slashed open the townscape for wider roads, expressways, parking lots; it increased the speed with which the viewer rushed through his environment; it separated him into a glass and steel cage; it cluttered the foreground with brash signage designed to catch a speeding eye, and with the litter of the cars themselves. No wonder people's visual sensitivities dulled!

When man passed through the townscape on foot or one horse, he made sure it was in scale with himself, not with his vehicle.

Notice the paving textures, brick and cobble in the old photo, or the rich, subtle surface of shop windows and signs. Then look at what has survived.

There seems, though, to be a lot more interest in the visual environment lately, especially the



Portsmouth, N.H. then and now. (Vision Inc. photos)

urban environment, the townscape, which is the most interesting kind.

If that's so our 60 years blindness may be coming to an end.